

## SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

# Mughal Society, Economy & Culture - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

## 00 MUGHAL SOCIETY, ECONOMY AND CULTURE

### FOCUS

Period: sixteenth-seventeenth core; bounded early-eighteenth continuation; integration and hierarchy together

### EVIDENCE

Anchor the claim in a dated text, material trace, traveller or regional record; then say what that source can and cannot establish.

### EXAM MOVE

Prelims: retain the exact discriminator. Mains: link this mechanism to hierarchy, exchange, institution or representation.

### CAUTION

Keep date, region, social location and source purpose visible. A strong conclusion is qualified, not evasive.

Original deterministic UPSC study plate | content-specific evidence, not a quotation

*Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.*

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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## BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

### PART III - Independent practice and remedies

#### Learning MCQ loop (24; keys A-B-C-D x6)

Original learning practice. Correct positions rotate A -> B -> C -> D without changing the underlying answer.

#### Q1. Which description best avoids a uniform-society error?

- A. A layered Mughal order whose hierarchy and mobility varied by region
- B. A rigid all-India legal pyramid
- C. A society without occupational difference
- D. A court-versus-peasant binary

**Answer: A. Explanation: The answer retains hierarchy and variation; the binary distractor suppresses merchants, professionals, artisans and local chiefs.**

#### Q2. Which late-Aurangzeb foreign-born statement is careful?

- A. Ancestry had no elite importance
- B. Under 10 percent of 1000-zat-and-above nobles were foreign-born in 1679-1707
- C. Foreign-born nobles were always a majority
- D. All Iranis/Turanis were foreign-born

**Answer: B. Explanation: Date and denominator control the claim. Iranis/Turanis are not identical to foreign-born persons.**

#### Q3. Mansab is best described as

- A. A port customs office
- B. A hereditary European title
- C. A service-rank system bureaucratising an aristocratic patronage world
- D. A village revenue tax

**Answer: C. Explanation: Mansab regulates service and rank without abolishing elite household power; hereditary title reverses the formal rule.**

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- D. A British landlord or a mere tax clerk

**Answer: D. Explanation: The correct answer blocks both anachronisms. Local claimant is true but too partial as a definition.**

#### Q5. Khud-kasht most carefully denotes

- A. A resident owner-cultivator with stronger resource and status position
- B. Only landless seasonal labour
- C. A transferable jagir holder
- D. Every village resident

**Answer: A. Explanation: Residence alone is insufficient: cultivation, ownership and resource position matter.**

**Q6. Pahi-kasht were often**

- A. Treasury officials
- B. Incoming cultivators settling new, surplus or abandoned land on possible concessions
- C. Non-cultivating nomads only
- D. A synonym for all khud-kasht

**Answer: B. Explanation: Pahi concerns entrant settlement. Khud-kasht reverses the resident/entrant distinction.**

**Q7. Layered Mughal land rights mean**

- A. Modern private ownership was complete
- B. Every zamindar owned every field
- C. Cultivation, occupancy, revenue claim and customary access could be separated
- D. State alone held every right

**Answer: C. Explanation: Layering defeats both simple state ownership and modern property assumptions.**

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- A. A total census of property
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- A. Labour and elite patronage show agency without proving general equality
- B. Women had no productive role
- C. Elite women prove equality for all
- D. Every inheritance practice was identical

**Answer: A. Explanation: Elite visibility is the closest false leap because archives privilege courtly women.**

**Q10. Mughal urbanisation included**

- A. Only army camps
- B. Imperial cities, ports, production/pilgrimage centres and qasbas
- C. Only coast cities
- D. One craft in every city

**Answer: B. Explanation: Functional diversity, not a single urban form, is the evidence-based approach.**

**Q11. Chandra's middle-strata argument names**

- A. No urban occupations
- B. A modern democratic middle class
- C. Merchants, clerks, professionals, brokers and master-craftsmen
- D. Only company employees

**Answer: C. Explanation: The listed groups refute Bernier's binary but should not be relabelled a modern middle class.**

**Q12. Imperial karkhanas were**

- A. Agrarian assignments
- B. All Mughal manufacture
- C. Only barracks
- D. Household/workshop/store systems alongside private production

**Answer: D. Explanation: Coexistence with private workshops and putting-out is the discriminator.**

**Q13. Aurang in the 2020 pair was not**

- A. The in-charge of the state treasury
- B. A warehouse/depot term
- C. A trade-infrastructure word
- D. Commercial storage

**Answer: A. Explanation: Aurang is a depot/warehouse. Treasury office is the specific mismatch.**

**Q14. Banian in company trade meant**

- A. Any foreign merchant
- B. An Indian broker-agent connecting purchase, credit and information
- C. Hereditary military rank
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**Answer: B. Explanation: Generic merchant is too broad; the intermediary function is decisive.**

**Q15. Mirasidar is safest as**

- A. A sea captain
- B. A mansabdar
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**Q16. A hundi was**

- A. A fortification permit
- B. A fixed silver coin
- C. A noble title
- D. A credit instrument transmitting value across distance/time

**Answer: D. Explanation: Hundi reduces risky cash movement; a coin is financial but not the instrument.**

**Q17. Banjaras are associated with**

- A. Moving bulk goods overland, often with oxen caravans
- B. Issuing coin
- C. Painting albums
- D. Holding mansabs

**Answer: A. Explanation: Transport of grain and bulk supply, not minting, is the function.**

**Q18. European companies were**

- A. Mughal departments
- B. Entrants into existing networks with growing naval-coercive capacity
- C. Irrelevant everywhere
- D. Instant masters of all trade

**Answer: B. Explanation: The answer avoids instant dominance and irrelevance alike.**

**Q19. Tavernier is especially relevant because he**

- A. Created mansab
- B. Wrote Ain-i-Akbari
- C. Elaborately discussed Indian diamonds and diamond mines
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**Q20. Monetisation is best described as**

- A. End of regional mints
- B. A universal cash-only economy
- C. Automatic rural welfare
- D. Important cash/revenue linkage while kind and barter persisted unevenly

**Answer: D. Explanation: Cash circulation does not abolish kind exchange or distribute welfare equally.**

**Q21. Technology is best judged as**

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- B. No technical craft skill
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**Answer: A. Explanation: Sectoral comparison avoids a civilisational stereotype and an industrial anachronism.**

**Q22. Printing requires the distinction between**

- A. Mass printing in every court
- B. Textile blocks, knowledge of presses and uneven institutional uptake
- C. Universal literacy
- D. No printing in India

**Answer: B. Explanation: The no-printing absolute is the central trap; medium and institution matter.**

**Q23. Aurangzeb and music: the careful claim is**

- A. No regional court continued music
- B. He invented dhrupad
- C. Singers left court but instruments, treatises and patronage continued
- D. All music ceased in India

**Answer: C. Explanation: Court restriction is not social extinction; the funeral anecdote is satirical.**

**Q24. Yogavasistha/Jug Basis matches**

- A. Bernier and Shah Jahan
- B. Tavernier and Jahangir
- C. Dara Shukoh and Aurangzeb
- D. Nizamuddin Panipati and Akbar's reign

**Answer: D. Explanation: This corrects the owner-risk: Dara's distinct works are Majma-ul-Bahrain and Surr-i-Akbar.**

**Broad MCQ bank (48; keys A-B-C-D x12)**

Original broad practice. Correct positions rotate A -> B -> C -> D without changing the underlying answer.

**Q1. In a source-disciplined reading, Which description best avoids a uniform-society error?**

- A. A layered Mughal order whose hierarchy and mobility varied by region
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- C. A court-versus-peasant binary
- D. A rigid all-India legal pyramid

**Answer: A. Explanation: The answer retains hierarchy and variation; the binary distractor suppresses merchants, professionals, artisans and local chiefs.**

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- B. Every village resident
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**Answer: A. Explanation: A second route to the answer: Residence alone is insufficient: cultivation, ownership and resource position matter.**

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- B. Entrants into existing networks with growing naval-coercive capacity
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### **Remedial MCQ bank (8; application-based, keys A-B-C-D x2)**

These questions repair common reasoning errors without repeating the learning loop.

**Q73. A pargana has a high assessed jama, but warfare and resistance sharply reduce actual collection. What is the safest inference?**

- A. The jama-hasil gap is wide, so the paper assessment cannot be treated as realised resources.
- B. The jagirdar privately owns the pargana.
- C. Monetisation has eliminated payment in kind.
- D. The high jama proves universal rural prosperity.

**Answer: A. Explanation: Jama is the assessed claim, while hasil is realised collection. A large gap warns against converting an administrative estimate into evidence of output, welfare or usable state income.**

**Q74. A court painting depicts women spinning and preparing textiles. How should it be used?**

- A. As proof that domestic production had disappeared.
- B. As evidence of possible gendered work, checked against textual and material sources and differentiated by class and region.
- C. As a complete occupational census for all Mughal women.
- D. As proof that elite and non-elite women enjoyed equal autonomy.

**Answer: B. Explanation: The image can support a bounded claim about work, but genre, patronage and social visibility limit representativeness. Corroboration prevents an illustrative scene from becoming a universal statistic.**

**Q75. A present-day conservation page describes the Taj Mahal's craftsmanship and material setting. Which historical use is methodologically valid?**

- A. It demonstrates private ownership of all cultivated land.
- B. It establishes the empire's exact share of world GDP.
- C. It supports bounded discussion of surviving techniques, materials and patronage, not universal social or economic conclusions.
- D. It proves that every Mughal artisan was prosperous.

**Answer: C. Explanation:** Heritage records are useful for the surviving monument and its material features. They do not measure empire-wide wages, equality, output or property relations.

**Q76. Large textile exports and bullion inflows are best combined with which conclusion?**

- A. Bullion inflow automatically raised real wages for all groups.
- B. Every region experienced identical commercial growth.
- C. European companies already controlled the entire Indian economy.
- D. Commercial dynamism could coexist with hierarchy, uneven bargaining power and regional variation.

**Answer: D. Explanation:** Trade indicators establish circulation and demand, not equal distribution. A strong answer keeps commercial expansion separate from universal welfare.

**Q77. Which pairing correctly distinguishes Dara Shukoh's two works?**

- A. Majma-ul-Bahrain compared mystical traditions; Sirr-i-Akbar was associated with Persian translations of the Upanishads.
- B. Majma-ul-Bahrain was the Persian Yogavasistha; Sirr-i-Akbar was Akbar's revenue manual.
- C. Both titles refer to the same illustrated manuscript.
- D. Both were composed by Nizamuddin Panipati.

**Answer: A. Explanation:** The titles belong to distinct intellectual projects. Conflating them also obscures Nizamuddin Panipati's separate Yogavasistha translation under Akbar.

**Q78. Which statement best separates imperial karkhanas from the wider craft economy?**

- A. Karkhanas were the only sites of production in the empire.
- B. They were court-linked stores and workshops within a larger field of household, market and merchant-organised production.
- C. They consisted entirely of unpaid agricultural labour.
- D. Their records provide a complete measure of all artisan welfare.

**Answer: B. Explanation:** Imperial workshops mattered for court consumption and specialised production, but private workshops, household manufacture and merchant advances also organised craft labour.

**Q79. What analytical link between banjaras and hundis is strongest?**

- A. Both were forms of monumental patronage.
- B. Both were hereditary Mughal ranks.
- C. Banjaras moved bulk goods while hundis helped move credit and value, jointly linking distant markets.
- D. Both made roads, rivers and brokers unnecessary.

**Answer: C. Explanation:** Physical carriage and financial instruments solved different circulation problems. Their interaction is more informative than treating either as the whole trade system.

**Q80. Why should a Persian chronicle be said to reflect and refract the spirit of its age?**

- A. Court patronage makes all its claims false.
- B. Its literary form has no bearing on historical use.
- C. It records every social group in equal detail.
- D. It reveals institutions and values through a genre, patron and audience that also shape silences and emphasis.

**Answer: D. Explanation:** A source can preserve real evidence while selecting and framing it. Genre and patronage require corroboration, not wholesale acceptance or rejection.

## Semantic-completeness coverage drills - Medieval Topic 24

| Drill               | Minimum route                                                | Fatal trap                      |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Agrarian layers     | khud-kasht/raiya/pahi + cattle/credit/mobility               | homogeneous peasant             |
| Zamindar/jagirdar   | local hereditary power vs transferable revenue assignment    | both tax clerks/owners          |
| Crafts              | household/workshop/advance/karkhana + textiles/metal/ships   | modern factory                  |
| Money/transport     | rupee/bullion/hundi/sarraf + banjara/road/river/coast        | all-cash frictionless market    |
| Merchants           | named Indian networks + European entrants                    | immediate company monopoly      |
| Towns               | capitals/ports/qasbas + middle strata                        | modern bourgeois class          |
| Gender/slavery      | labour/agency + hierarchy/source silence                     | elite women represent all       |
| Education/languages | plural institutions and publics                              | Persian replaced every language |
| Culture             | institutional synthesis + patronage + inequality             | decorative Hindu-Muslim mix     |
| Technology          | high skill + selective adoption + weak science-workshop link | stagnation/takeoff binary       |
| Sources             | jama/hasil + traveller/factory/material limits               | estimate equals census          |
| PYQ                 | five direct routes with exact key status                     | invent official objective keys  |

## PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

### PART II - Exact PYQs and direct routes

#### Exact routed UPSC PYQs: wording, option order and answer status

##### 2018 Prelims GS-I Q73

Which one of the following foreign travellers elaborately discussed about diamonds and diamond mines of India?

A. Francois Bernier B. Jean-Baptiste Tavernier C. Jean de Thevenot D. Abbe Barthelemy Carre

**INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: B. Jean-Baptiste Tavernier (high confidence).** A local official key is not held. Tavernier was a French jeweller-merchant whose account is specialised in diamonds/mines. Bernier is the property debate traveller; Thevenot and Carre are not the specialised diamond source. Original option order retained.

##### 2019 Prelims GS-I Q1

With reference to Mughal India, what is/are the difference/differences between Jagirdar and Zamindar?

1. Jagirdars were holders of land assignments in lieu of judicial and police duties, whereas Zamindars were holders of revenue rights without obligation to perform any duty other than revenue collection.
2. Land assignments to Jagirdars were hereditary and revenue rights of Zamindars were not hereditary.

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

A. 1 only B. 2 only C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

**INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: D. Neither 1 nor 2 (high confidence).** Jagirdari was a transferable revenue assignment, not hereditary land assignment in the asserted contrast. Zamindars could have hereditary rights and were not limited to bare collection. Original option order retained.



### 2020 Prelims GS-I Q21

With reference to the history of India, consider the following pairs:

1. Aurang : In-charge of treasury of the State
2. Banian : Indian agent of the East India Company
3. Mirasidar : Designated revenue payer to the State

Which of the pairs given above is/are correctly matched?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2 and 3 only C. 3 only D. 1, 2 and 3

**INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: B. 2 and 3 only (high confidence).** Aurang is warehouse/depot, so Pair 1 fails. Banian fits company agent/broker and Mirasidar the exam's revenue-payer frame. Original option order retained.

### 2022 Prelims GS-I Q94

"Yogavasistha" was translated into Persian by Nizamuddin Panipati during the reign of:

A. Akbar B. Humayun C. Shahjahan D. Aurangzeb

**INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A. Akbar (high confidence).** Nizamuddin Panipati's Persian Yogavasistha/Jug Basis belongs to Akbar's reign. Dara Shukoh's Majma-ul-Bahrain and Sirr-i-Akbar are distinct. Original option order retained.

### 2020 GS-I Q12

**Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (250 words, 15 marks)**

The direct ~250-word examiner-grade answer appears as Mains 1 below. It treats "reflect" as qualified "refract," uses named genres and evidence, and ends with corroboration.

### Twelve examiner-grade solved Mains questions

Each answer follows claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification -> verdict.

**Mains 1. 2020 GS-I Q12 (15 marks, 250 words): Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.**

#### Model solution

Persian literary sources are indispensable to medieval India, but "reflect" requires qualification. Court chronicles such as Barani's Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi and Abul Fazl's Akbarnama disclose ideas of sovereignty, hierarchy and legitimate rule; Ain-i-Akbari turns revenue categories, offices and courtly order into an imperial knowledge project. Memoirs such as Baburnama and Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri offer more personal registers, while Sufi malfuzat such as Fawaid-ul-Fuad reveal devotional language and urban religious worlds. Translation projects such as Razmnama show scholarly contact across Sanskrit and Persian fields.

These sources reveal political vocabulary, literary aesthetics, patronage, religious debate and administrative aspiration. Badauni's dissenting tone itself prevents their reduction to unbroken official praise. Yet genre is a limit: chronicles seek legitimacy, compendia classify for rule, and memoirs centre privileged observers. Peasants, many women, oral communities and non-court regions remain unevenly visible; silence is not absence.

Persian letters, biographies and regional chronicles further register networks of service, learning and memory that a single imperial chronicle cannot exhaust. They also remind us that Persian was a working language of administration and literary exchange, not merely a royal ornament. Their evidence must still be located in patronage and circulation before it is made representative.

Persian literary sources therefore refract rather than mechanically mirror the spirit of the age. A reliable reconstruction reads them with vernacular literature, inscriptions, coins, paintings, buildings, archaeology and travellers. Their partiality is historically productive because it identifies the priorities and exclusions through which medieval power represented itself.

**Why this earns marks:** It directly answers the directive, uses named genres/texts, explains reach and silence, and ends with corroboration.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **comment** requires a direct position on “Mains 1. 2020 GS-I Q12 (15 marks, 250 words): Persian literary sources of medieval India...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For “Mains 1. 2020 GS-I Q12 (15 marks, 250 words): Persian literary sources of medieval India...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

### **Mains 2. Discuss social hierarchy and mobility in Mughal India. (15 marks, 250 words)**

#### **Model solution**

Mughal society was layered, not frozen. Emperor and household, mansabdars, local chiefs/zamindars, merchants, professionals, artisans, cultivators and labourers held different claims on office, income and status. Mansab made service rank legible, yet khanazad advantage shows social reproduction despite formal non-heredity. The dated 1679-1707 evidence that foreign-born nobles were under 10 percent of 1000-zat-and-above total corrects Bernier's foreigner generalisation without erasing ancestry prestige.

Local power complicates a court-only account. Zamindars combined revenue claims, clan/caste links, armed following and local information; their scale ranged from village gentry to rajas. Mobility came through service, military employment, trade, migration and settlement. Pahi cultivators could enter new land on concession, while Virji Vohra's agency network shows commercial mobility. Yet caste, gender, access to cattle/credit and patronage constrained outcomes. Gulbadan or Jahanara illuminate elite female agency, not general equality.

The correct verdict is hierarchy with channelled movement, not either a rigid caste prison or equal opportunity.

**Why this earns marks:** It defines structure, gives mansab/zamindar/pahi/merchant evidence and distinguishes mobility from equality.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Mains 2. Discuss social hierarchy and mobility in Mughal India. (15 marks, 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For “Mains 2. Discuss social hierarchy and mobility in Mughal India. (15 marks, 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

### **Mains 3. Examine the agrarian structure of Mughal India. (20 marks, 250 words)**

#### **Model solution**

Mughal agrarian structure combined productive expansion with differentiated rights and fiscal pressure. Khud-kasht were resident owner-cultivators with stronger resource position; raiyati/muzarian categories covered varied owners and tenants; pahi-kasht entered new or abandoned land, often on concession. These are local social categories, not a uniform all-India caste schedule.

Rights were layered: cultivators held labour/occupancy claims, zamindars revenue and social claims, and the state assessment. Patil, muqaddam, chaudhuri, qanungo, patwari and deshmukh mediated with regional variation. Clearance, migration and resettlement extended cultivation; pattas, seed and cattle could enable it, while debt could bind it. Wells, Persian wheels, tanks and canals served different ecological settings.

Cash demand and cotton, indigo, sugarcane and oilseeds connected some regions to markets, but food crops and kind exchange remained important. Bernier observed extraction; his claim that transferable jagirs prevented improvement is qualified by layered rights and expansion evidence. Thus the order was productive and integrated but negotiated, unequal and insecure.

**Why this earns marks:** It connects categories, rights, ecology, market and source debate instead of reciting revenue formulae.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **examine** requires a direct position on “Mains 3. Examine the agrarian structure of Mughal India. (20 marks, 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For “Mains 3. Examine the agrarian structure of Mughal India. (20 marks, 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

#### **Mains 4. Analyse zamindars in the Mughal rural order. (10 marks, 150 words)**

##### **Model solution**

Zamindars were local power-holders rather than mere collectors. The term covered a range from village-linked claimants to chiefs and rajas, often with armed retainers, garhis, caste-clan ties and local knowledge. Zamindari rights could be hereditary, divisible and saleable, and joined revenue share to prestige.

The state needed these actors for collection, order and cultivation but also tried to regulate dues and incorporate chiefs. This created cooperation, mansab links and resistance. A zamindar could assist pahi settlement and improvement while also making exactions.

They were therefore both bridge and constraint between centre and countryside. Scale is the required qualification: a small rural holder cannot be equated with an autonomous raja.

**Why this earns marks:** It defines, gives mechanisms and ends with regional/scale qualification appropriate to ten marks.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on “Mains 4. Analyse zamindars in the Mughal rural order. (10 marks, 150 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For “Mains 4. Analyse zamindars in the Mughal rural order. (10 marks, 150 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

#### **Mains 5. Assess women's work and agency in Mughal society. (15 marks, 250 words)**

##### **Model solution**

Women's history must begin with labour as well as elite visibility. Agriculture, spinning, embroidery and domestic production linked women to rural and craft economies, even when courtly records understate them. Paintings may suggest work and material practice, but cannot be read as an occupational census.

Elite evidence establishes particular agency. Gulbadan Begum's Humayun-nama provides a courtly female voice; Nur Jahan's visibility and Jahanara's patronage show that imperial women could command resources and cultural authority. Such evidence is strong precisely because its courtly setting is named, and weak when made a measure of all women's condition.

Purdah, marriage, widowhood, inheritance and sati varied by class, caste, region and community. Access to cattle, credit, market and household protection altered actual options. Caste hierarchy and domestic servitude constrained many lives. The sound conclusion is differentiated agency inside a strongly unequal social order.

**Why this earns marks:** It includes productive work, named elite evidence, source caution and intersectional qualification.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Mains 5. Assess women's work and agency in Mughal society. (15 marks, 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For “Mains 5. Assess women's work and agency in Mughal society. (15 marks, 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

### **Mains 6. Discuss Indian merchants and overseas trade in seventeenth-century Mughal India. (15 marks, 250 words)**

#### **Model solution**

Seventeenth-century India was a major Indian Ocean participant without being a European monopoly. Surat/Cambay, Hugli/Balasore, Masulipatnam/Pulicat and Malabar joined different hinterlands to Red Sea, Gulf, Southeast Asian and European circuits. Textiles, silk, grain, sugar, indigo and saltpetre moved outward; horses, metals and luxury goods came in. Bullion helped silver circulation but was not a welfare index.

Indian agency appears in Virji Vohra's commercial network and Abdul Ghaffur's maritime activity. Hundi, sarraf, broker, gumashta and banian practices linked credit and information; banjaras and rivers connected inland supply. Companies entered an already developed system with chartered capital and coercive naval capacity. Factories remained dependent on farmans and were land-vulnerable, while maritime leverage grew.

The best verdict is commercial dynamism with Indian merchant centrality, regional differentiation and a gradual coercive-company challenge.

**Why this earns marks:** It combines ports, commodities, named merchants and institutions without unsupported trade totals.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on “Mains 6. Discuss Indian merchants and overseas trade in seventeenth-century Mughal India....”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For “Mains 6. Discuss Indian merchants and overseas trade in seventeenth-century Mughal India....”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

### **Mains 7. Critically evaluate Bernier as a source for Mughal society and economy. (15 marks, 250 words)**

#### **Model solution**

Bernier is valuable for courtly inequality, political economy and peasant insecurity, and he raised questions about jagirs and property that historians still test. His observation of elite consumption and extraction should not be discarded because he was European.

Yet he compared Mughal arrangements with European landed assumptions. His claim that transferable jagirs and absence of private property destroyed improvement is qualified by occupancy, zamindari, settlement and commercial evidence. His "no middle state" is challenged by merchants, shops, clerks, qazis, physicians, brokers and master-craftsmen. This does not turn the countryside into a secure idyll: debt, cesses, flight and coercion remain real possibilities.

Bernier is a situated witness, strong for visible inequality and weak as a total theory. Read him with Ain, regional records, vernacular material and other travellers.

**Why this earns marks:** It preserves observation, explains the comparison lens, supplies counter-evidence and avoids blanket dismissal.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Mains 7. Critically evaluate Bernier as a source for Mughal society and economy. (15 marks,...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Mains 7. Critically evaluate Bernier as a source for Mughal society and economy. (15 marks,...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

#### **Mains 8. Evaluate technology and production in Mughal India without teleology. (20 marks, 250 words)**

##### **Model solution**

Mughal India combined craft excellence with uneven technical diffusion, so a straight road-to-industrial-Britain comparison misleads. Textiles, dyes, jewellery and shipbuilding display skilled production; Indian cloth was globally competitive. Yet water pumps, furnace/bellows scale, cannon casting, screws/springs, glass and telescopic observation show constraints in specified sectors.

Printing requires a three-way distinction: textile block printing, encounter with presses and uneven institutional uptake in Persian/vernacular worlds. "No printing" is therefore false. Possible explanations for selective adoption include abundant low-cost skilled labour, merchant advances without tool investment, and weak linkage between elite/scientific knowledge and productive improvement. Caste inheritance may shape training but cannot be the single cause because new trades recruited entrants.

Commercialisation did not automatically produce mechanisation. The appropriate conclusion is sectoral and institutional, rejecting both stagnation stereotype and premature industrialisation.

**Why this earns marks:** It balances strengths/limits, corrects printing, and uses multi-causal analysis rather than civilisational judgement.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Mains 8. Evaluate technology and production in Mughal India without teleology. (20 marks,...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Mains 8. Evaluate technology and production in Mughal India without teleology. (20 marks,...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

### Mains 9. Explain Mughal architecture and painting as institutional productions. (20 marks, 250 words)

#### Model solution

Architecture and painting were collective institutions, not emperor-alone creations. Humayun's Tomb joins charbagh and Timurid-Persian bridge; Akbar's Agra Fort and Fatehpur Sikri mobilise red sandstone and trabeate-arcuate forms; Itimad-ud-Daulah anticipates marble/inlay; Taj Mahal, Red Fort and Jama Masjid stage Shahjahani formality. Patron, master builder, artisan, quarry, transport and labour form the production chain.

Akbar's kitabkhana/karkhana organised collaborative painting; Hamzanama is its key example. Jahangir's portrait/albums and Mansur's natural studies show court taste and representation. Later artist dispersal assisted Rajasthan and Pahari transformation rather than ending art.

These media expressed sovereignty and composite craftsmanship, but not universal harmony or welfare. Paintings can illuminate costume and ideology yet are not photographs. Institutional history restores makers, material and political economy to a ruler-by-ruler list.

**Why this earns marks:** It couples named monuments/artwork systems to makers, evidence limits and social context.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Mains 9. Explain Mughal architecture and painting as institutional productions. (20 marks,...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Mains 9. Explain Mughal architecture and painting as institutional productions. (20 marks,...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

### Mains 10. Discuss literature and translation as cultural interaction under the Mughals. (15 marks, 250 words)

#### Model solution

Cultural interaction was institutional and linguistic, not a simple fusion. Persian was imperial language of administration and high literature, while Akbar's Maktab Khana sponsored Sanskrit-Persian dialogue through Razmnama and Ramayana projects. Precision is decisive: Nizamuddin Panipati's Persian Yogavasishta/Jug Basis belongs to Akbar, whereas Dara Shukoh's secure associations are Majma-ul-Bahrain and Sirr-i-Akbar.

Vernacular production widened cultural fields. Tulsidas, Surdas, Rahim, Raskhan and Keshavdas; Eknath, Tukaram and Ramdas; Sikh Guru traditions/Adi Granth demonstrate varied language, patronage and audience. Persian and regional languages coexisted rather than cancelling each other.

Translation and literature reveal elite dialogue, vernacularisation and plural cultural publics. They do not prove caste hierarchy, gender inequality, orthodoxy or political coercion vanished.

**Why this earns marks:** It uses exact correction, named texts/authors and distinguishes coexistence from equality.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 10. Discuss literature and translation as cultural interaction under the Mughals. (15...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Mains 10. Discuss literature and translation as cultural interaction under the Mughals. (15...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or



scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

**Mains 11. "Composite culture was real, but not socially egalitarian." Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)**

**Model solution**

Composite culture is observable through collaborative workshops, translation, architecture, painting, music and regional patronage. Maktab Khana translations, Akbar's painting workshop and artist movement into Rajasthan/Pahari courts show mechanisms of interaction rather than vague harmony. Persian and vernacular literary fields coexisted.

But cultural contact did not equal distribution of power. Caste hierarchy, gendered restrictions, elite patronage, orthodoxy and coercion persisted. Translation remained largely elite; court art represented sovereignty; elite women's visibility did not prove ordinary autonomy.

The verdict is relational: forms were made through contact and adaptation inside an unequal social order.

**Why this earns marks:** It defines the claim through concrete institutions, then separates interaction from equality.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Mains 11. "Composite culture was real, but not socially egalitarian." Discuss. (10 marks,...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Mains 11. "Composite culture was real, but not socially egalitarian." Discuss. (10 marks,...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

**Mains 12. Assess the Mughal economy: prosperity, integration and limits. (20 marks, 250 words)**

**Model solution**

The Mughal economy combined agrarian productivity, commercial integration and cultural consumption, but gains were uneven and technical transition incomplete. Silver currency, revenue demand, roads, sarais, rivers, hundis and merchant networks linked many regions. Textiles, indigo, sugar, saltpetre and foodstuffs moved through Surat, Hugli and Masulipatnam; Virji Vohra and Abdul Ghaffur show merchant agency.

Expansion used clearance, pahi settlement and investment in cattle, seed and water, while khud-kasht, raiyati/muzarian, pahi, service and labour groups held unequal resources. Zamindars mediated revenue/local power; credit and cesses could turn growth into insecurity. Bullion and court demand cannot be universal welfare.

Craft skill coexisted with selective technology adoption. The best judgement is dynamic, integrated and productive within a hierarchical agrarian order-neither golden-age abundance nor stagnant isolation.

**Why this earns marks:** It synthesises agriculture, trade, finance, class and technology with named evidence and a graded verdict.

**Demand decoding:** The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Mains 12. Assess the Mughal economy: prosperity, integration and limits. (20 marks, 250...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

**Detailed examiner-grade model status:** The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

**Executable exam-length answer / compression plan:** For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

**How to improve this answer:** For "Mains 12. Assess the Mughal economy: prosperity, integration and limits. (20 marks, 250...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.